Q3 Close Operational Response Plan

I'll spend the first 10 minutes freezing the payment damage, spend most of my attention on the one problem with a hard 5:00 PM deadline, and delegate the vendor outage with a clear communications plan, all without bypassing compliance.

Triage sequence and resource allocation

I ranked each issue by what gets worse if I wait, what can't be undone, and what we control. Revenue comes first, with a 10-minute payment freeze ahead of it, and the 3PL outage is third and delegated.

Priority	Issue	Why it's prioritized here	Owner	My time
1	Revenue bottleneck	It is the only issue with a hard, irreversible cutoff and a fix we own. The payment cleanup and the vendor outage both stay recoverable after 5:00 PM.	Me, with IT on-call, Sales, Compliance	~60%
2	Payment record corruption	I'll freeze it now; reconciliation can run past 5:00 PM. It takes minutes, it stops harm that compounds with every run, and it costs nothing to do before the bigger problem.	Finance lead, with script owner from IT	~20%
3	3PL outage	I can't repair a vendor's system. A capable owner can triage the 1,200+ orders by SLA exposure and customer tier, push the vendor for an ETA, and	Customer Success lead alongside the vendor account manager with me overseeing.	~20%

Priority	Issue	Why it's prioritized here	Owner	My time
		send proactive notices, which does more good than my attention would.		

In practice, the first 10 minutes go to the payment freeze because it is the cheapest action and stops the damage from growing. Then I move into the revenue workstream, get the pipeline fixed and staged by 5:00 PM, and hold the contract for the audit.

The trade-off I'm accepting is the 3PL outage gets the least of my time, so SLA breaches continue through the hour. The mitigation is proactive customer notice since the final fix is something we don't control. I'll re-prioritize if the vendor gives no ETA by 4:30 PM, or if a supplier is threatening to pause services critical to fulfillment.

By 3:45, the payments are frozen, and every workstream has an owner. By 4:15, the audit decision is made, and at 5:00 I confirm the Q3 outcome.

Timeline table: 3:30 to 5:00 PM

Workstream	3:30 to 3:45 PM	3:45 to 4:15 PM	4:15 to 5:00 PM
Revenue	IT diagnoses pipeline; Compliance audit starts	IT fix on a 25-minute time limit; expedite audit steps	Hold for audit; stage onboarding for clearance
Payments	Freeze script and runs; snapshot the data	Scope double and missed payments against bank records	Pay critical suppliers; request refunds and credits
3PL outage	Owner gets vendor ETA and order exposure list	Triage orders by SLA risk and customer tier	Send customer notices; re-rank if no ETA by 4:30
Leadership	Name owners; open one shared channel, and share the initial update	3:45 update to CEO and CFO; 15-minute check-ins	4:15 and 5:00 updates; confirm the Q3 outcome

Team kickoff (send at about 3:35 PM)

Channel post: Q3 close: 3 major issues, owners and check-ins
Owners and first asks:

- **Revenue** (enterprise contract stuck in Pending): I'm leading, with @IT on-call. IT, please diagnose the provisioning failure on a 25-minute timebox and report back at 4:00 PM. @Compliance, please open the audit review now.
- **Payments** (corrupted vendor records): @Finance lead, with @IT. Pause the automation script and all pending payment runs now, and snapshot the vendor table before changing anything.
- **3PL outage:** @Customer Success lead. Get the vendor's ETA and pull the affected orders by SLA exposure.

Post an update here every 15 minutes, even if it's "no change." Flag blockers right away. No one bypasses a compliance control, including as a workaround.

Executive update to CEO and CFO #1 (send at about 3:45 PM)

To: CEO, CFO

Subject: Q3 close: three urgent issues; the team is working a fix, updating you at 4:15

Body: We've had three issues come through around 3:30 PM. The enterprise contract is stuck in pending, and it represents 15% of our Q3 target. I know we have a hard 5:00 PM deadline, so I'm seeing to it personally. The payment issue is contained, and I've delegated the 3PL outage to an owner so we can keep things moving with my oversight.

Issue	Status	Risk	Immediate action	Owner
Enterprise contract stuck in "Pending"	Provisioning pipeline failed; IT diagnosing	Q3 revenue recognition at risk if not corrected and billed by 5:00 PM	25-minute IT timebox on the fix; Compliance review started in parallel	Me, IT on-call
Corrupted vendor payment records	Automation paused, payment runs frozen	Double payments to some vendors; missed payments to key suppliers threatening to pause services	Scoping affected vendors; paying critical suppliers manually under dual approval	Finance lead, script owner with IT, with me overseeing
3PL outage	Vendor system outage halting nationwide outbound	High, but outside our control	Get a vendor ETA, triage orders by SLA exposure,	Customer Success lead alongside vendor account

Issue	Status	Risk	Immediate action	Owner
	fulfillment; SLAs breaching on 1,200+ orders		send proactive customer notices	manager with me overseeing

What I need from you:

- **CFO:** Can you confirm the criteria for recognizing this contract's revenue in Q3, and whether the payment errors affect the Q3 close?
- **CEO:** I will not bypass a compliance control to hit the cutoff. If that becomes the only path to Q3 revenue, you'll hear it from me at the 4:15 PM update.

Thanks,

Katrina Reid

Executive update #2 at 4:15 PM

To: CEO, CFO

Subject: Q3 close: 4:15 PM checkpoint

Revenue: [Pipeline status]. I'm holding the contract for the standard 24-hour audit and not overriding it. The contract is signed, so I expect this revenue to move to Q4, pending your confirmation of the treatment. Sales and I are informing the client at [time]. Onboarding starts once the audit clears, expected [time].

Payments: [X] vendors double-paid and [Y] suppliers missed. The script is paused, and critical suppliers are being paid manually under dual approval by [time]. Finance is assessing Q3 close impact.

3PL: [Vendor ETA, or "no ETA yet"]. [X] orders are at SLA risk, and customer notices are [sent / going out at time].

Next update at 5:00 PM.

Thanks,

Katrina Reid

Email to customers with orders affected by the 3PL outage (send at about 4:40 PM)

To: Customer
Subject: Update on your order [#]

Hi [Name],

Our fulfillment partner is having a system outage that is delaying shipments, and your order [#] is affected. We're sorry for the delay.

We don't have a restart time yet and will update you by [time], and we'll send a new delivery date as soon as it's confirmed.

You can reach me at [contact] with any questions.

Best,
Katrina Reid

Executive update #3 at 5:00 PM

To: CEO, CFO
Subject: Q3 close: 5:00 PM outcome

Contract: Not onboarded or billed before the cutoff, held for the compliance audit. Expected clearance [time]; the client has been informed.

Payments: [Status of supplier payments and refund requests]. Open items: [list].

3PL: [Status]. [X] orders still affected, with notices out.

Action Plan for Tomorrow: Audit clearance and onboarding, payment reconciliation, and root cause reviews on all three issues. I'll send a written summary by [time].

Thanks,

Katrina Reid

Containment plan: payment record corruption

Stop new payments, preserve the data, pay critical suppliers from verified records, then repair. The first four steps happen inside the hour; the rest follows.

1. **Stop the damage (3:30 - 3:45).** Pause the automation script and every scheduled or pending payment run. Switch vendor payments to manual release with dual approval. Snapshot the current vendor payment table before anyone touches it, so the evidence is preserved.
2. **Scope the impact (3:45 - 4:15).** Finance and IT pull the payment log and compare it with bank records and the AP ledger, not the corrupted table. Produce two lists: vendors double-paid (amount, date) and vendors missed or short-paid, ranked by how soon each can pause service.
3. **Protect critical suppliers (4:15 - 5:00).** Pay the missed key suppliers manually from verified AP records under dual approval, starting with the ones threatening to pause services. Call each one directly: the error was ours, here is the payment date and reference.

Email to critical supplier with a missed payment

Subject: Your payment for [invoice #]: our error and your payment date

Hi [Name],

A system error on our side caused your payment of [amount] for [invoice #] to be missed. That's our mistake, and I'm sorry for the disruption. We're issuing the payment manually and you'll receive it by [date and time], reference [#].

I'm your direct contact at [phone/email], and please tell me if services will be affected before then.

Best,
Katrina Reid

4. **Handle the double payments (4:15 - 5:00).** Contact each vendor to request a refund or a credit against future invoices. Log every case for CFO sign-off, largest amounts first.

Email to vendor that was double-paid

Subject: Duplicate payment on [invoice #]: refund or credit request

Hi [Name],

A system error on our side sent you two payments of [amount] on [date] for [invoice #]. Could you confirm you received both?

We'd ask that you either refund the duplicate or apply it as a credit against your next invoice, whichever you prefer. To protect against fraud, we'll confirm any bank details by phone with a contact we already have on file.

I'm your direct contact at [phone/email]. Please let me know how you'd like to proceed.

Best,
Katrina Reid

5. **Flag the Q3 close.** Ask Finance whether the errors require adjusting entries or cash-position changes before the books close, and tell the CFO.
6. **Restore integrity (after the hour).** Rebuild the table from the last known-good backup in a staging copy, reconcile it to bank and AP records, and have Finance validate it before it goes live. The script stays off until it is fixed and tested.
7. **Prevent a repeat.** Run a root cause review. Add pre-payment checks for duplicate payments and batch totals outside the expected range, require second-person approval on automated batches, test every automation change in a sandbox first, and update the SOP with a named owner.

Bonus Scenario: Sales VP and 24-hour audit

Email to VP of Sales and Head of Compliance

To: VP of Sales, Head of Compliance

Subject: Holding enterprise contract (no override)

Hi [VP name] and [Head of Compliance],

I'm holding the enterprise contract for the standard 24-hour audit and will not execute a manual override. No past issues with this tier describes history, not this client's data. The audit is a mandatory data-privacy control. A privacy failure would cost us more than a one-quarter timing shift, and because the contract is signed, we are moving revenue, not losing it.

Next steps:

- **Compliance:** Please start the audit now and tell me which steps can run in parallel.
- **Sales:** I'm getting Sales on a call with me and the client to set a firm go-live time.
- **Operations:** I'm briefing the CFO on the Q3 impact and will have provisioning fixed and staged so onboarding starts the moment the audit clears.

I know this costs us the quarter number, but I'd rather explain a delay than a breach.

Thanks,

Katrina Reid

Client message about the onboarding timeline

Subject: Your onboarding timeline

Hi [Name],

Thank you again for choosing us. Before we activate your account, our security and data-privacy review, which we complete for every enterprise client to protect your data, needs to finish. It takes about 24 hours, and we're also completing a final technical setup on our side.

We expect your account to be ready by [date and time]. [Sales rep] and I would like to call you at [time] to walk through the plan. Please let us know if that time works for you.

Best,

Katrina Reid

SOP modification

Start the compliance and data-privacy audit when an enterprise deal enters final contract review, not after it closes.

The 24-hour audit sits between signature and provisioning, so a quarter-end deal collides with the revenue deadline. Moving the trigger earlier removes the slowdown without weakening compliance. Here’s the new SOP:

- When an enterprise-tier deal reaches the final contract review stage in the CRM, it automatically opens an audit request to Compliance.
- Compliance runs the audit while Legal and Sales finish negotiating, so clearance is ready by the time the contract is signed.
- The provisioning step checks for "audit cleared" status. Nothing is bypassed; the check just stops being on the critical path.

How we measure success: The share of enterprise deals with audit clearance in place at signature, and the cycle time from signature to provisioning.

Post-incident review

What I think needs review afterward:

- Whether the CRM-to-provisioning pipeline needs monitoring and alerts
- Whether we have a backup 3PL option
- Whether automation changes need a sandbox and approval step

I'd run a blameless review on all three and fold the fixes into SOPs with named owners.